

Design Document

Generational Communication Training for New Interns

Project Title: Communicating Up: Building Confidence Across Generations

Company: NorthStar Rail

Training Type: New Intern Onboarding / Communication Skills / Early-Career Professional Development

ADDIE Phase: Design

Primary Audience: New graduate interns

Recommended Format: 90-minute interactive instructor-led workshop

Delivery Mode: In person or virtual

Design Priority: High participation, practical application, and learner engagement

1. Course Overview

NorthStar Rail will provide a communication training session for new graduate interns as part of the onboarding program. The session will help interns communicate more confidently and professionally with senior managers, project leads, and leaders across the organization.

Because the client has identified **low participation rate** as a concern, this training will not use a traditional lecture-heavy format. Instead, the course will be designed as an interactive workplace communication challenge where interns analyze realistic scenarios, rewrite messages, practice conversations, and make decisions in teams.

The training design follows corporate training best practices by aligning learning objectives with business needs, using scenario-based activities, and focusing on practical application instead of passive content delivery.

2. Business Problem

New interns are technically capable but often lack experience communicating with senior employees in a professional workplace setting.

Common challenges include:

Challenge	Workplace Impact
Interns hesitate to speak up	Missed opportunities to clarify tasks or contribute ideas
Interns ask vague questions	Managers spend extra time identifying the real issue

Interns use overly casual communication	Messages may appear unclear or unprofessional
Interns over-explain in emails or updates	Key information may be missed
Interns feel nervous receiving feedback	Slower development and reduced confidence
Interns avoid senior leaders	Lower visibility and weaker relationship-building

The client also noted that participation in traditional training can be low. Therefore, the design must solve two problems:

1. **Performance problem:** Interns need stronger upward communication skills.
2. **Engagement problem:** The learning experience must feel attractive enough to increase participation.

3. Training Goal

By the end of the training, new interns will be able to communicate with senior managers and leaders using clear structure, professional tone, active listening, and feedback-response strategies in common workplace situations.

4. Design Goal

The design goal is to create a training experience that feels practical, relevant, and engaging for young professionals.

The session should feel less like:

“A trainer tells interns how to communicate.”

And more like:

“Interns solve realistic workplace communication challenges, compare choices, practice better responses, and leave with tools they can use immediately.”

5. Target Learners

Category	Description
Learners	New graduate interns

Career stage	Entry-level, 0–1 year of full-time professional experience
Work environment	Hybrid corporate office, virtual meetings, project teams, and possible field exposure
Strengths	Educated, motivated, technology-comfortable, eager to contribute
Challenges	Limited workplace communication experience, low confidence with senior
Likely mindset	“I want to sound professional, but I do not always know what to say.”
Learning preference	Fast-paced, practical, social, realistic, low-pressure practice

6. Learning Objectives

By the end of the session, learners will be able to:

Object ive	Learners Will Be Able To...	Assessment Method
1	Identify common communication expectations between interns and senior leaders	Group discussion / scenario debrief
2	Differentiate casual, professional, and leadership-facing communication styles	Message comparison activity
3	Apply a clear structure for emails, chats, and verbal updates	Message rewrite challenge
4	Demonstrate how to ask specific questions and clarify expectations	Pair practice
5	Respond to feedback using a professional and growth-oriented approach	Feedback response scenario
6	Create a 30-day personal communication action plan	Individual action plan

These objectives are action-oriented because the training should focus on what interns can do after the session, not only what they can remember.

7. Instructional Strategy

Main Strategy

The course will use a **scenario-based, challenge-driven workshop model**.

Instead of long lecture sections, learners will move through short communication challenges based on realistic intern-manager situations.

Design Principles

Design Principle	Application
Practical over theoretical	Use real workplace examples instead of long explanations of generations
Short input, active practice	Introduce a concept briefly, then ask learners to use it
Safe practice	Let interns practice difficult conversations before doing them at work
Peer learning	Interns compare responses and learn from each other
Manager realism	Scenarios reflect how senior leaders actually expect information
Immediate transfer	Learners leave with a checklist and 30-day action plan

This approach is supported by adult learning theory, which emphasizes relevant and practical learning, and social learning theory, which emphasizes learning by observing others and comparing behaviors.

8. Engagement Strategy

Because the client specifically wants higher participation, engagement must be designed into the course structure.

Proposed Experience Theme

“The Communication Challenge Lab”

The session will be framed as a lab where interns test and improve communication choices.

This makes the session feel more active than a typical training.

Engagement Methods

Engagement Method	How It Works	Why It Helps Participation
Scenario challenges	Learners solve realistic communication problems	Feels relevant and practical
Message makeover	Learners rewrite weak messages into stronger ones	Easy to participate, low risk
Polls or quick votes	Learners choose the best response	Encourages participation from quiet learners
Pair practice	Learners rehearse short conversations	Builds confidence before larger group sharing
Team discussion	Small groups compare communication choices	Reduces pressure

“What would you do?” moments	Learners make judgment calls	Creates curiosity
Communication scorecard	Learners evaluate clarity, tone, and action	Makes expectations concrete
Action plan	Learners choose one behavior to apply in their internship	Supports transfer

Participation Design Rule

Every 7–10 minutes, learners should be asked to do something.

Examples:

Time Interval	Learner Action
Opening	Vote on common intern communication fear
Module 1	Discuss manager expectations
Module 2	Rewrite a vague update
Module 3	Choose the best Teams message
Module 4	Practice asking a clearer question
Module 5	Respond to feedback scenario
Closing	Write one 30-day action commitment

This helps prevent the training from feeling like a lecture.

9. Learning Experience Design

The session will follow this learning flow:

Experience Flow

Stage	Purpose	Learner Experience
Hook	Capture attention	“Choose the message you would send to a manager” poll
Discover	Understand why communication differs	Discuss what managers need from interns
Learn	Introduce simple communication tools	Short frameworks and examples

Practice	Apply the tools	Message rewrite, role-play, feedback scenario
Reflect	Connect to personal behavior	Identify one communication habit to improve
Transfer	Support workplace application	30-day action plan and job aid

This follows a practical version of Gagné’s instructional flow: gaining attention, informing learners of objectives, providing practice, giving feedback, and supporting transfer. The learning theory reference identifies Gagné’s events and cognitive load management as useful instructional design principles.

10. Course Structure

Recommended Duration: 90 Minutes

Section	Time	Focus	Activity Type
Opening: Communication Reality Check	10 min	Why communicating up matters	Poll + discussion
Module 1: Understanding Communication Expectations	15 min	What senior managers need from interns	Scenario discussion
Module 2: The CLEAR Communication Framework	20 min	Structure for updates, questions, and requests	Mini-demo + practice
Module 3: Professional Tone in Email and Chat	20 min	Adjusting casual/vague messages	Message makeover challenge
Module 4: Speaking Up and Asking Better Questions	15 min	Meeting participation and clarification	Pair practice
Module 5: Feedback and Follow-Up	5 min	Responding professionally to feedback	Scenario response
Closing: 30-Day Communication Commitment	5 min	Transfer to workplace	Action plan

Total: **90 minutes**

11. Core Communication Framework

To make the training memorable, interns need one simple structure.

CLEAR Framework

Letter	Meaning	Intern-Friendly Explanation
C	Context	What is the situation?
L	Lead with the point	What is the main message or request?
E	Explain briefly	What does the manager need to know?
A	Ask or action	What do you need from them, or what will you do next?
R	Recap next step	Confirm deadline, owner, or follow-up

Example

Weak message:

Hi, I'm confused about the report. Can you help?

CLEAR version:

Hi Alex, I reviewed the safety report draft and have one question about the incident-rate calculation on page 3. Could you confirm whether I should use the monthly average or the year-to-date figure? Once confirmed, I can complete the draft by Thursday afternoon.

This framework will be used across email, chat, verbal updates, and meeting participation.

12. Module Design

Opening: Communication Reality Check

Item	Design
Time	10 minutes
Purpose	Create relevance and psychological safety
Activity	Poll: "What feels hardest when communicating with senior managers?"
Learner action	Vote, discuss, connect to real intern experience
Facilitator role	Normalize the challenge and frame the session as practice, not judgment

Module 1: Understanding Communication Expectations

Item	Design
Time	15 minutes
Purpose	Help interns understand what managers usually need
Key idea	Senior leaders often value clarity, context, timing, ownership, and concise updates
Activity	“Manager Lens” scenario discussion
Learner action	Review a vague intern message and identify what the manager still needs
Output	List of manager expectations

Module 2: The CLEAR Communication Framework

Item	Design
Time	20 minutes
Purpose	Give learners a repeatable structure
Key idea	Clear communication reduces uncertainty and shows ownership
Activity	CLEAR message-building practice
Learner action	Convert a weak update into a structured manager-ready update
Output	Completed CLEAR communication example

Module 3: Professional Tone in Email and Chat

Item	Design
Time	20 minutes
Purpose	Help interns adapt tone by audience and channel
Key idea	Professional does not mean stiff; it means clear, respectful, and useful
Activity	Message Makeover Challenge
Learner action	Teams rewrite casual or unclear messages
Output	Stronger email/chat examples

Module 4: Speaking Up and Asking Better Questions

Item	Design
Time	15 minutes
Purpose	Build confidence in meetings and manager conversations
Key idea	Good questions are specific, prepared, and connected to next steps
Activity	Pair role-play: “Ask the manager”
Learner action	Practice asking a clearer question using context + specific ask
Output	Improved question script

Module 5: Feedback and Follow-Up

Item	Design
Time	5 minutes
Purpose	Help interns respond to feedback professionally
Key idea	Feedback is part of workplace learning, not a personal failure
Activity	Choose the best response
Learner action	Select and improve a response to manager feedback
Output	Feedback response sentence starter

Closing: 30-Day Communication Commitment

Item	Design
Time	5 minutes
Purpose	Support transfer to the job
Activity	Personal action plan
Learner action	Choose one behavior to apply in the next 30 days
Output	Individual communication commitment

13. Activity Design Summary

Activity	Format	Participation Level	Learning Purpose
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Communication fear poll	Individual	Low-risk	Open participation
Manager Lens scenario	Small group	Medium	Understand expectations
CLEAR update practice	Pair / small group	High	Apply structure
Message Makeover	Team	High	Improve tone and clarity
Ask Better Questions role-play	Pair	High	Practice verbal communication
Feedback response choice	Individual / group	Medium	Build judgment
30-day action plan	Individual	High	Support transfer

14. Assessment Strategy

This training will use **performance-based formative assessment**, not a formal test.

Because the skill is communication, learners should demonstrate ability through realistic tasks.

Assessment Point	Evidence of Learning
Manager Lens scenario	Learners can identify missing context and unclear requests
CLEAR practice	Learners can structure a manager-ready update
Message Makeover Challenge	Learners can improve tone and professionalism
Ask Better Questions role-play	Learners can ask a specific and appropriate question
Feedback response activity	Learners can respond constructively to feedback
Action plan	Learners can name one behavior they will apply on the job

15. Materials and Deliverables

Deliverable	Purpose
Slide deck	Facilitate the interactive workshop
Trainer guide	Provide facilitator script, timing, activity instructions, and debrief questions
Participant worksheet	Capture activity responses, reflection, and action plan
CLEAR communication checklist	Job aid for use after training
Scenario cards	Support group activities and role-play

Post-session survey	Measure relevance, confidence, and participation
Manager check-in prompt	Support transfer after 30 days

16. Technology and Delivery Requirements

In-Person Delivery

Requirement	Purpose
Projector or screen	Display slides and scenarios
Printed worksheets	Support practice and reflection
Scenario cards	Small-group activity prompts
Sticky notes or index cards	Quick response activities
Room setup	Tables or small groups preferred

Virtual Delivery

Requirement	Purpose
Teams or Zoom	Live delivery
Polling feature	Quick participation
Chat	Low-pressure response option
Breakout rooms	Pair and small-group practice
Digital worksheet	Learner practice and action planning

17. Accessibility and Inclusion Considerations

The training should create a safe and inclusive environment.

Consideration	Design Response
Quiet learners may avoid speaking	Use polls, chat, and pair practice before large-group
Interns may fear being judged	Use fictional scenarios instead of asking learners to share
Generational topic may create stereotypes	Focus on communication preferences, role expectations, and workplace context

English may not be every learner's first language	Use simple language, examples, and written sentence starters
Different confidence levels	Provide structured frameworks and optional sharing

The course should avoid framing younger employees as “the problem.” The message should be:

Different people and roles may have different communication expectations. This training helps interns adapt with confidence.

18. Reinforcement and Transfer Plan

To avoid a one-time training event, the design should include light reinforcement after the session.

Timing	Reinforcement
During training	CLEAR checklist introduced and practiced
Immediately after training	Participants keep worksheet and job aid
First 2 weeks	Interns apply CLEAR to one manager update
30 days	Manager check-in prompt: “What communication habit has improved?”
End of internship	Reflection question added to intern program evaluation

19. Evaluation Plan

Level	Method	Success Indicator
Level 1: Reaction	Post-session survey	Learners rate the session as relevant, practical, and engaging
Level 2: Learning	Scenario activities and message rewrites	Learners demonstrate clearer communication choices
Level 3: Behavior	30-day manager check-in	Managers observe clearer questions, better updates, and stronger follow-up
Level 4: Results	Intern onboarding feedback	Interns feel more confident; managers report fewer communication misunderstandings

Evaluation should focus not only on attendance or completion, but also on workplace behavior change.

20. Design Risks and Mitigation

Risk	Mitigation
Learners see the topic as boring	Use challenge-based activities and realistic scenarios
Learners feel judged	Use fictional examples and supportive facilitation
Session becomes too theoretical	Limit concept explanation and prioritize practice
Generational discussion becomes stereotypical	Focus on communication expectations, not age labels
Participation remains low	Use polls, small groups, pair work, and frequent learner actions
Skills do not transfer	Provide job aid and manager check-in prompt

21. Final Design Recommendation

The recommended solution is a **90-minute interactive onboarding workshop** titled:

Communicating Up: Building Confidence Across Generations

The training should be designed as a **Communication Challenge Lab**, not a traditional lecture. Learners will work through realistic intern-manager situations, practice communication choices, rewrite messages, role-play short conversations, and create a personal 30-day action plan.

This design directly responds to the client's new requirement for a more attractive and participatory learning experience while still maintaining a professional corporate training standard.

Approved Design Direction Before Lesson Planning

Before moving into the detailed lesson plan, our approved design direction is:

Design Decision	Direction
Training format	90-minute interactive instructor-led workshop
Experience style	Communication Challenge Lab

Main framework	CLEAR communication framework
Learning method	Scenario-based, social, practical, low-lecture
Participation strategy	Learner activity every 7–10 minutes
Main deliverables	Slides, trainer guide, worksheet, job aid, scenario cards, survey
Transfer tool	30-day communication action plan